

Data Analyst

Practice session

Candidate: Priya Nair

Date: 2026-08-13

Interview language: English

Overall summary

The candidate declined to answer all core competency questions during this practice session, leaving their technical and communication skills completely unsubstantiated. To succeed in an actual interview, the candidate must prepare concrete examples from their résumé, particularly regarding SQL, Looker, and stakeholder management. Reviewing past projects and structuring them using standard frameworks will be essential for the next attempt.

Strengths

- The candidate has a relevant professional background in retail data analytics as outlined in their résumé.
- The candidate was direct and clear when they were unable to recall details, avoiding fabricated responses.

Areas to improve

- Preparation of concrete examples from past experiences to answer behavioral and technical questions.
- Ability to discuss technical architectures, database schemas, and tool-specific workflows such as Snowflake and Looker.
- Structuring answers using established frameworks like STAR or Problem-Approach-Tradeoffs-Outcome.

Question-by-question feedback

Your resume mentions writing SQL queries against a Snowflake warehouse to support marketing requests. Could you describe the structure of the tables you queried most frequently for those requests?

What went well: The candidate was direct about their inability to answer rather than fabricating details.

What to improve: The candidate declined to answer the question, leaving their SQL and database structure experience completely unsubstantiated. In future interviews, it is critical to describe the schema, tables, and join keys used.

PROBLEM, APPROACH, TRADEOFFS, OUTCOME

At Brightfield Commerce, the marketing team needed to track campaign performance against transactional data. The Snowflake warehouse contained a central orders fact table and dimension tables for customers and marketing campaigns. The problem was that the campaign table tracked clicks at a session level, while orders were recorded at a transaction level. To resolve this, I approached the query by performing a left join from the orders table to the sessions table using the customer ID and a timestamp window function to attribute the sale to the correct campaign. I weighed using a simple join versus a window function; a simple join would have double-counted orders if a user clicked multiple campaigns, so I used a row number function partitioned by order ID to select only the last touchpoint. This approach ensured accurate attribution, resulting in a clean dataset that the marketing team used to optimize their ad spend.

STAKEHOLDER COMMUNICATION & COLLABORATION

Your résumé mentions that you partnered directly with the VP of Merchandising to present monthly business reviews. Could you describe how you prepared for those reviews and how you communicated your findings?

What went well: The candidate politely requested to move to the next question when they could not recall the details.

What to improve: The candidate declined to answer, leaving their stakeholder communication experience unsubstantiated. To improve, prepare a structured narrative detailing how you prepare data, align with stakeholders, and present insights to executive-level leaders.

STAR

At Brightfield Commerce, the VP of Merchandising needed to understand monthly regional sales performance to make inventory decisions. My task was to prepare and present the monthly business review. I began by pulling the monthly sales and inventory data from our warehouse, identifying key trends such as a sudden drop in apparel sales in the East region. I then synthesized these findings into a concise three-slide deck, focusing on the reasons behind the numbers rather than just the raw data. During the meeting, I presented these insights clearly, recommending a redistribution of inventory to the West region where demand was higher. As a result, the VP approved the inventory shift, which helped recover regional sales by eight percent the following month.

Your résumé notes that you built and maintained a weekly merchandising dashboard in Looker that was used by three regional teams. Could you tell me about the key metrics you included in that dashboard and how you determined what to display?

What went well: The candidate was direct in indicating they wanted to move to the next question.

What to improve: The candidate declined to answer, leaving their Looker dashboarding experience unsubstantiated. In future interviews, explain the business requirements, the specific metrics chosen, and how you designed the dashboard for usability.

PROBLEM, APPROACH, TRADEOFFS, OUTCOME

The three regional merchandising teams at Brightfield Commerce were relying on manual spreadsheets, which caused delays and inconsistent metrics. My task was to build a standardized weekly Looker dashboard. I approached this by first interviewing the regional managers to understand their core KPIs, which were sales revenue, inventory turnover, and sell-through rate. I faced a tradeoff between displaying highly granular daily transaction data or keeping the dashboard high-level for quick decision-making. I chose to build a high-level summary view with drill-down capabilities, allowing users to click into specific product categories without cluttering the main view. The outcome was a fully automated Looker dashboard that saved the regional teams six hours of manual reporting weekly and ensured a single source of truth for merchandising decisions.

Recommendations for next time

Before your next practice run, review your résumé thoroughly and write down at least two specific projects for each bullet point. Practice structuring these projects using the STAR framework for general questions and the Problem-Approach-Tradeoffs-Outcome framework for technical questions. Ensure you can speak comfortably about database schemas, metrics, and stakeholder interactions.

Full transcript

Q1. Hello. Thank you for your time today. My name is Alex. I will be conducting this interview for the Data Analyst position at Lumen Retail Analytics. My colleague, Sara, is also joining us for this session.

(no answer recorded)

Q2. Hello. I am Sara, from the people operations team. It is a pleasure to meet you today. To begin our conversation, could you please introduce yourself, and share a brief overview of your background and what brings you here today?

I have 5 years of experience in data analyst working on multiple position and this role was fit according to my interest and experience

Q3. Thank you for the introduction. It is clear you have built a solid foundation over the past five years. Since you mentioned this role fits your experience, I would like to understand that background a bit better. Could you share a specific example of a project where you used SQL to analyze complex data and deliver actionable insights for your stakeholders?

I don't remember

Q4. I understand. It can sometimes be difficult to recall a specific project on the spot. Since you have five years of experience, perhaps we can look at your work more broadly. Could you tell me about the typical types of data you analyzed in your most recent role?

I don't remember

Q5. Understood, let us move forward. Your resume mentions writing SQL queries against a Snowflake warehouse to support marketing requests. Could you describe the structure of the tables you queried most frequently for those requests? [SQL & Data Querying](#)

Let's move to the next question

Q6. Understood. Let us move on to the next area. Your résumé mentions that you partnered directly with the VP of Merchandising to present monthly business reviews. Could you describe how you prepared for those reviews and how you communicated your findings?

[Stakeholder Communication & Collaboration](#)

Let's move to the next question

Q7. Understood. Let us proceed to the next topic. Your résumé notes that you built and maintained a weekly merchandising dashboard in Looker that was used by three regional teams. Could you tell me about the key metrics you included in that dashboard and how you determined what to display? [BI Dashboarding & Data Visualization](#)

Move to the next

Q8. Understood, we will move forward. That brings us to the end of the structured questions, so I would now like to share some personalized feedback on your performance today.

Sure

Q9. Thank you for your time today. Let us look at the SQL and querying portion of our discussion. You chose to move past the question regarding your Snowflake table structures. In a professional interview, it is important to walk through the actual schema you worked with to demonstrate your technical depth. For instance, if you were asked about this, you could structure your response by explaining the problem, your approach, the tradeoffs, and the outcome. You might explain that the marketing team needed to attribute sales to specific campaigns. You would describe the tables, such as a central orders fact table and a campaigns dimension table. Then, explain your approach, like using a left join combined with a window function to attribute the sale to the last click. You could discuss the tradeoff of using a window function over a simple join to avoid double-counting orders. This shows the interviewer your SQL logic and database design knowledge.

(no answer recorded)

Q10. Thank you. Let us discuss the stakeholder communication question. You preferred to skip the question about your collaboration with the VP of Merchandising. When speaking with stakeholders, especially at the executive level, preparation and clear communication are key. For a question like this, using the Situation, Task, Action, and Result framework is highly effective. You could describe the situation, where the VP needed monthly business reviews to make inventory decisions. Your task was to prepare these reviews. Your action would be how you analyzed the monthly sales data, synthesized it into a concise presentation, and focused on actionable recommendations rather than just raw numbers. Finally, share the result, such as how your recommendations led to concrete business decisions. This structure demonstrates your ability to influence business leaders.

(no answer recorded)

Q11. Let us address the question about your Looker dashboard. You chose to move to the next question, which left this key resume claim unsubstantiated. In a technical interview, we want to understand your design choices and tool proficiency. A strong way to answer this is through the Problem, Approach, Tradeoffs, and Outcome structure. You could explain that the regional teams were using manual spreadsheets, which was the problem. Your approach was to interview the managers and identify key metrics like sales and inventory turnover. You could discuss the tradeoff of showing high-level summaries versus granular tables, explaining why you chose a drill-down design to maintain dashboard performance and usability. The outcome would be the automated dashboard that saved hours of manual work. This shows your technical judgment and user-centric design process.

(no answer recorded)

Q12. That concludes all of our feedback for today's session. I wish you the very best of luck with your upcoming interview.

(no answer recorded)

This practice report is a coaching tool to help you prepare — treat it as guidance, not a guarantee of how any real interview will go.